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Old English Shorter Poems

VOLUME II

WISDOM AND LYRIC



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DUMBARTON OAKS
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HARVARD UNIVERSITY PRESS
CAMBRIDGE, MASSACHUSETTS
LONDON, ENGLAND

2014

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Deor

Welund him be wurman wræces cunnade,
 an-hydg eorl earfoþa dreag,
 hæfde him to gesipþe sorge ond longap,
 winter-cealde wræce; wean oft onfond,
 5 siþþan hine Niðhad on nede legde,
 swoncre seono-bende on syllan monn.
 Þæs ofereode; þisses swa mæg.

Beadohilde ne wæs hyre broþra deap
 on sefan swa sar swa hyre sylfre þing,
 10 þæt heo gearolice ongieten hæfde
 þæt heo eacen wæs; æfre ne meahte
 þriste gebencan, hu ymb þæt sceolde.
 Þæs ofereode; þisses swa mæg.

We þæt Mæðhilde monge gefrugnon:
 15 wurdon grundlease Geates frige
 þæt hi seo sorg-lufu slæp ealle binom.
 Þæs ofereode; þisses swa mæg.

Deodric ahte þritig wintra
 Mæringa burg; þæt wæs monegum cup.
 20 Þæs ofereode; þisses swa mæg.

We geascodan Eormanrices
 wylfenne gepoht; ahte wide folc
 Gotena rices; þæt wæs grim cyning.

— S —
 — R —
 — L —

Deor

Welund experienced exile among his damascened work,
 the resolute warrior endured hardships,
 had sorrow and longing for companions,
 winter-cold exile; he often found woe,
 after Nithhad laid constraints upon him,
 5 supple sinew-bonds on the better man.
 That passed away; so can this.

Beadohild was not as pained in heart about
 the death of her brothers as she was about her own state,
 that she had clearly perceived
 that she was with child; she could never
 10 think unflinchingly about how that must turn out.
 That passed away; so can this.

We have heard about the moans of Mæthhild:
 Geat's passions were bottomless
 15 so that sorrowful love took all sleep from her.
 That passed away; so can this.

Theodric possessed for thirty winters
 the fortress of the Goths; that was known to many.
 20 That passed away; so can this.

We have learned of Eormanric's
 wolfish thought; he controlled widely the people
 of the kingdom of the Goths; that was a cruel king.

— S —
 — R —
 — L —

POEMS FROM *THE EXETER BOOK*

25 Sæt secg monig sorgum gebunden,
 wean on wenum, wyscte geneahhe
 þæt þæs cyne-rices ofercumen wære.
 Þæs ofereode; þisses swa mæg.

 Siteð sorg-cearig, sælum bidæled,
 on sefan sweorceð, sylfum þinceð
 30 þæt sy endeleas earfoða dæl.
 Mæg þonne gepencan, þæt geond þas woruld
 witig Dryhten wendeþ geneahhe:
 eorle monegum are gesceawað,
 wislicne blæd, sumum weana dæl.

 35 Þæt ic bi me sylfum secgan wille,
 þæt ic hwile wæs Heodeninga scop,
 dryhtne dyre. Me wæs Deor noma.
 Ahte ic fela wintra folgað tilne,
 holdne hlaford, oþ-þæt Heorrenda nu,
 40 leoð-cræftig monn lond-ryht gepah
 þæt me eorla hleo ær gesealde.
 Þæs ofereode; þisses swa mæg.

100

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DEOR

Many a warrior sat bound with sorrows,
 in expectation of woe, wished frequently
 25 that that kingdom should be overcome.
 That passed away; so can this.

 The sorrowful one sits, bereft of joys,
 darkening in spirit, it seems to him
 that his portion of hardships is endless.
 30 He may then think that throughout this world
 the wise Lord makes frequent changes:
 to many a person he grants honor,
 true glory, to some a portion of woe.

 I want to relate this about myself,
 35 that for a while I was the poet of the Heodeningas,
 dear to my lord. My name was Deor.
 For many winters I possessed a good service,
 a gracious lord, until Heorrenda now,
 the man skilled in song craft, received the land-right
 40 that the protector of men before gave to me.
 That passed away; so can this.

101

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Wulf and Eadwacer

Leodum is minum swylce him mon lac gife;
willað hy hine aþecgan, gif he on þreat cymeð.

Ungelic is us.

Wulf is on iege, ic on oþerre.

5 Fæst is þæt eg-lond, fenne biworpen.
Sindon wæl-reowe weras þær on ige;
willað hy hine aþecgan, gif he on þreat cymeð.

Ungelice is us.

Wulfes ic mines wid-lastum wenum dogode;
10 þonne hit wæs renig weder ond ic reotugu sæt,
þonne mec se beadu-cafa bogum bilegde,
wæs me wyn to þon, wæs me hwæpre eac lað.

Wulf, min wulf, wena me þine
seoce gedydon, þine seld-cymas,
15 murnende mod, nales mete-liste.

Gehyrest þu, Eadwacer? Ucerne earmne hwelp
bireð wulf to wuda.

Þæt mon eape tosliteð þætte næfre gesomnad wæs,
uncer giedd geador.

— S —
— R —
— L —

Wulf and Eadwacer

For my people, it is as if someone gave them a gift of sacri-
fice;

they want to kill him if he comes into their company.

It's different for us.

Wolf is on one island, I on another.

Secure is that land, surrounded by a fen.

Cruel men are there on that island;
they want to kill him if he comes into their company.

It's different for us.

I dogged my Wolf with far-wandering expectations;
when it was rainy weather and I sat mournful,

when the one active in battle embraced me,
it was a joy to me; it was also hateful to me.

Wolf, my wolf, my longings for you

have made me sick, your rare visits,

a mourning mind, not at all want of food.

Do you hear, Eadwacer, vigilant one? Wolf will bear our
wretched whelp off to the forest.

One may easily tear apart what was never joined,
our song together.

— S —
— R —
— L —

The Wife's Lament

Ic þis giedd wrece bi me ful geomorre,
minre sylfre sið. Ic þæt secgan mæg,
hwæt ic yrmþa gebad, siþþan ic up aweox,
niwes oþþe ealdes, no ma þonne nu.

- 5 A ic wite wonn minra wræc-siþa.
Ærest min hlaford gewat heonan of leodum
ofer yþa gelac; hæfde ic uht-ceare
hwær min leod-fruma londes wære.
Ða ic me feran gewat folgað secan,
10 wineleas wrecca, for minre wea-þearfe.
Ongunnon þæt þæs monnes magas hycgan
þurh dyrne geþoht þæt hy todælden unc
þæt wit gewidost in woruld-rice
lifdon laðlicost, ond mec longade.
15 Het mec hlaford min her hired niman;
ahte ic leofra lyt on þissum lond-stede,
holdra freonda. Forþon is min hyge geomor.
Ða ic me ful gemæcne monnan funde
—heard-sæligne, hyge-geomorne,
20 mod-miþendne, morþor-hycgendne—
bliþe gebæro ful oft wit beotedan
þæt unc ne gedælde nemne deað ana
owiht elles; eft is þæt onhworfen;
is nu seo neawest swa hit no wære,

— S
— R
— L

The Wife's Lament

I recite this poem about myself, very sad,
about my own experience. I can relate
what miseries I've endured recently and long ago
since I grew up, never more than now.

- I have always suffered the torment of my exile journeys. 5
First my husband departed from his people
over the tossing of the waves; I had anxiety before dawn
about where my lord might be in the land.
Then, to seek place in a retinue, I, a friendless exile,
set out traveling because of my grievous need. 10
The kinsmen of that man began to consider
through secret thought that they might separate us
so that we two, as far apart as possible in the worldly
kingdom,
would live most horribly, and it made me suffer longing.
My husband commanded me to take up my household here; 15
I had in this plot of ground few loved ones,
gracious friends. Therefore my mind is sad.

- When I found a man very similar to me
—luckless, humorless,
secretive, intending violence— 20
with joyful demeanor, we two very often boasted
that nothing but death would separate us at all;
S afterward, that changed;
R our closeness, our friendship is now as if it
L

- 25 freondscipe uncer. Sceal ic feor ge neah
mines fela-leofan fæhðu dreogan.
Heht mec mon wunian on wuda-bearwe,
under ac-treo in þam eorð-scræfe.
Eald is þes eorð-sele; eal ic eom oflongad.
30 Sindon dena dimme, duna up-hea,
bitre burg-tunas, brerum beweaxne,
wic wynna leas. Ful oft mec her wraþe begeat
from-siþ frean. Frynd sind on eorþan,
leofe lifgende, leger weardiað,
35 þonne ic on uhtan ana gonge
under ac-treo geond þas eorð-scrafu.
Ðær ic sittan mot sumor-langne dæg,
þær ic wepan mæg mine wræc-siþas,
earfoþa fela; forþon ic æfre ne mæg
40 þære mod-ceare minre gerestan,
ne ealles þæs longapes þe mec on þissum life begeat.
A scyle geong mon wes an geomor-mod,
heard heortan geþoht, swylce habban sceal
bliþe gebæro, eac þon breost-ceare,
45 sin-sorgna gedreag. Sy æt him sylfum gelong
eal his worulde wyn, sy ful wide fah
feorres folc-londes, þæt min freond siteð
under stan-hliþe storme behrimed,
wine werig-mod, wætre beflowen
50 on dreor-sele. Dreogeð se min wine
micle mod-ceare; he gemon to oft
wynlicran wic. Wa bið þam þe sceal
of langope leofes abidan.

— S —
— R —
— L —

- hadn't been. Far and near I must
endure the hostility of my beloved. 25
I was ordered to live in a grove,
under an oak tree in the earth cave.
This earth hall is old; I am completely possessed with
longing. The valleys are dark, the hills steep,
30 the earthworks bitter, covered with briars,
a settlement deprived of joys. Very often my husband's
departure cruelly held me here. Lovers are on earth,
beloved living ones, occupying their beds,
while I walk alone at dawn 35
under the oak tree through this earth cave.
There I may sit the summer-long day,
where I can lament my exile journeys,
my many hardships; therefore I cannot ever
gain rest from my grief 40
nor from all the longing that has held me in this life.
A young person must always be sad in mind,
the thought of the heart hard, and will also have
a joyful demeanor, heart anxiety in addition,
a multitude of perpetual sorrows. May all joy in the world 45
be dependent on the self alone, may the person be outlawed
very far away
to a distant country so that my friend will sit
under a rocky slope covered with frost by a storm,
a weary-minded friend, conveyed by water
to desolate lodgings. My friend will suffer 50
great grief, will often remember
a more joyful dwelling. Woe is for the one who must
await a beloved one with longing.

— S —
— R —
— L —

NOTES TO THE TRANSLATIONS

sluggish man attracts reproaches that he lacks courage): See *A Proverb from Winfrid's Time*.

187 *stan* (stone): This word could refer either to a gem stone or to a game piece in chess, for example.

191 *fæþþo* (a state of feud): The description of feud here to line 200 offers an important backdrop for understanding the whole of *Beowulf* and specifically the Cain and Abel material relating to Grendel, lines 102–14.

THE ORDER OF THE WORLD

22 *þæt he wislice woruld fulgonge* (of engaging wholly and wisely in the world): The meaning of this clause is not clear. Bosworth-Toller translates, “that he wisely perfect the world”; the DOE translates, “in completing wisely his worldly ways.”

THE RHYMING POEM

On the multiple difficulties this poem presents in almost every line, see the Introduction. Note also that wherever possible in the translation, I have tried to replicate the effect of the rhyme in the Old English without doing violence to the sense—as I perceive it—of the original. Rhyme, therefore, appears only sporadically in the translation. For a successful attempt to replicate all the rhyme in modern English, see Earl, “Hisperic Style,” 188.

2 *ond þæt torhte geteoh* (and brought forth that brightness): This could also be translated, for example, as “and that bright doctrine” or “firmament” or “matter.” See the note on this line and the notes on subsequent lines in Muir, *Exeter Anthology*.

8 *lisse mid long leoma gebongum* (gently past trees with long branches): It seems that the horses carry the speaker across plains and through forests. As noted in Muir, *Exeter Anthology*, Eric G. Stanley translates this line as “gently with long contacts with branches.”

46 *brond-bord* (burning thought): There is much debate about what this word actually means. See Macrae-Gibson, *Riming Poem*,

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48–50. Lockett, *Anglo-Saxon Psychologies*, 85–86, interprets the word, which is literally “fire hoard,” to mean “burning thought” or “fire thought.”

59 *wyrde* (fate): See note to *The Wanderer*, line 5.

67 *searo-bwīt solap, sumur-hat colað* (brilliant whiteness gets defiled, summer heat cools): See *Latin-English Proverbs*, line 3.

78–79 *ond æt nyhstan nan nefne se neda tan balawun her gebloten* (and at the last none except the inescapable lot appointed for men): The translation is Klinck’s, *Old English Elegies*, 158.

DEOR

For Germanic analogues for this poem, see Calder et al., *Sources and Analogues II*, 65–69.

1 *Weland*: Weland, the legendary Germanic smith whose metal-work was unparalleled and who was coveted for it by a king Nithhad. His story is told in the ninth-century (?) Old Norse poem *Völundarkviða* (Lay of Weland) in the poetic Edda and in the twelfth- or thirteenth-century Norwegian *Þiðreks saga* (Saga of Thidrek) by Dietrich von Bern. Prompted by his evil wife, the king has Weland’s hamstrings cut so he cannot flee and then puts him on an isolated island where he will produce weapons, armor, and adornments for the king alone. The loss of freedom, mobility, and one of his prize swords enrages Weland, so he bides his time until he can have his revenge. The king’s two sons visit the island to see the precious treasure Weland has wrought. He urges them to come again, alone; they do, and he beheads them both. He then skillfully encases their skulls in silver and gives them to the king as cups, makes jewels out of their eyes for the queen, and forges a necklace out of their teeth for the king’s daughter, Beadohild, whom he later rapes and impregnates (see the following stanza). When the horror of the skull gift is revealed to the stunned and inconsolable king, a laughing Weland raises himself aloft and out of captivity with the help of a coat of feathers he and his brother, Egill, have made.

him be wurman (among his damascened work): The meaning of

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NOTES TO THE TRANSLATIONS

wurma is unknown but has been taken to refer to “snakes” or “swords” or “rings” or, metaphorically, the damascened patterning on swords. See discussions in Pope and Fulk, *Eight Old English Poems*, 114; and Hill, *Minor Heroic Poems*, 18–19.

7 *Þæs ofereode; þisses swa mæg* (That passed away; so can this): Literally, “It passed over from that; it can from this, too.” This line is one of the most perplexing and discussed of Old English verse because of the unclear references for “that” and “this.” The line also seems to shift meaning from one stanza to the next.

8 *Beadobilde*: See note to line 1, above.

14 *Mæðbild*: There is no known source for this tale. *Mange* (moans) occurs uniquely here and is of uncertain meaning. It has been thought to mean “moans,” “affairs,” or “many.” See Hill, *Minor Heroic Poems*, 48.

18 *Ðeodric*: Probably Theodoric the Ostrogoth, who ruled Italy from 493–526. See *Widsith*, line 115.

19 *Mæringa burg* (fortress of the Goths): Ravenna, Italy.

21 *Eormanrices* (Eormanric): See *Widsith*, lines 8, 18, 88, and 111, and *Beowulf*, line 1201.

36 *Heodeninga* (Heodeningas): The name of a Germanic tribe.

37 *Deor*: The name of this poem’s poet. As an adjective, it means “brave” or “bold”; as a noun, it means “animal.”

39 *Heorrenda*: Deor’s successor and the poet or singer Horant in the Middle High German poem, *Kudrun*. Horant’s talents help his king (Heoden in Old English) secure the love of a beautiful maiden name Hild, daughter of Hagen (Hagena in Old English). For summaries of the story, see Pope and Fulk, *Eight Old English Poems*, 119–20; and Hill, *Minor Heroic Poems*, 20–21, 108.

WULF AND EADWACER

2, 7 *willað by hine aþecgan* (they want to kill him): The verb *aþecgan* according to the DOE means “to serve with food” or “feed” but contextually here “to kill.” Since the context is so unclear, the verb has also been taken to mean “receive” or “welcome.”

9 *Wulfes ic mines wid-lastum wenum dogode* (I dogged my Wolf with

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THE WIFE’S LAMENT

far-wandering expectations): The meaning of the verb *dogian* is unknown, but given the lupine or animal imagery throughout the poem, “dogged” seems a good choice for a modern English equivalent of its past tense. For a full discussion of this hypothesized verb, see Osborn, “Dogode in *Wulf and Eadwacer*”; see also Sarah L. Higley, “Finding the Man Under the Skin: Identity, Monstrosity, Expulsion, and the Werewolf,” in *The Shadow-Walkers: Jacob Grimm’s Mythology of the Monstrous*, ed. Tom Shippey (Tempe, Arizona, 2006), 369–75. Some editors have emended the word to *bogode* (thought about).

10 *reotugu* (mournful): That the speaker of the poem is female is indicated by the feminine form of this adjective.

11 *bogum bilegde* (embraced me): *bogum* can mean upper arms, boughs, or the forequarters of an animal. The whole phrase has been taken to mean sexual intercourse. See entry in DOE.

16 *Eadwacer* (Eadwacer, vigilant one): Since this word can be either a proper name or a common noun, I translate using both senses of it.

Uncerne earmne hwelp (our wretched whelp): The enigmatic whelp has been interpreted as a wolf cub, a child, a metaphor for the lovers’ relationship, a reference to Wolf, a reference to Eadwacer, a reference to the poem itself, and a reference to the consequences of outlawry within the context of Old Norse law and literature.

THE WIFE’S LAMENT

1 *ful geomorre* (very sad): The adjective has a feminine ending, which indicates that the speaker is female.

6 *blaford* (husband): This begins the pattern of imagery in the poem that implicitly likens the husband-wife relationship to the lord-retainer relationship.

21 *blife gebero* (with joyful demeanor): This is a squinting modifier that can qualify “the man” in the preceding clause or “we” in the following clause. With Pope and Fulk, *Eight Old English Poems*, I opt for the latter. See the note on this phrase in their edition.

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NOTES TO THE TRANSLATIONS

- 24 *swa hit no wære* (as if it hadn't been): See *The Wanderer*, line 96.
 25 *freondscipe* (friendship): See *The Husband's Message*, line 19.
 26 *fæbðu dreogan* (endure the hostility): The word *fæbðu* usually means "feud." Its use here could be a continuation of the lord-retainer imagery begun in line 6. See the note in Pope and Fulk, *Eight Old English Poems*.
 28 *under ac-treo in þam eorð-scræfe* (under an oak tree in the earth cave): This obscure line remains obscure despite many attempts to clarify it. See the notes in Cassidy and Ringler, *Bright's Old English Grammar*; and Pope and Fulk, *Eight Old English Poems*. The importance of the oak in Anglo-Saxon society is attested in *The Rune Poem*, lines 77–80: "The oak is the nourishment of pork for human beings; it often fares over the gannet's bath; the ocean tests whether the oak has noble faith."
 37 *sumor-langne dæg* (summer-long day): See *Juliana*, line 495.
 40–53 The ambiguity of these lines has given rise to a number of interpretations that affect one's view of the whole poem. Is this passage a curse or a gnomic meditation, for instance? See the Introduction.
 49 *wætre beflowen* (conveyed by water): Thus Pope and Fulk, *Eight Old English Poems*, instead of "surrounded by water."

RESIGNATION (B): AN EXILE'S LAMENT

For an edition and translation of *Resignation (A)*, see Christopher A. Jones, ed. and trans., *Old English Shorter Poems*, vol. 1, *Religious and Didactic*, DOML 15 (Cambridge, Mass., 2012), 110–15. On the relationship of this poem to *Resignation (A)*, see the Introduction to this volume and Jones, *Old English Shorter Poems*, 354–55. Line numbers in other editions are continuous from *Resignation (A)*, so that *Resignation (B)* begins with line 70, a practice that has no authority if the two are fragments of separate poems. Accordingly, the edition here begins with line 1.

- 6 *blīpe mode; nu ic gebunden eom* (with a blithe spirit; now I am firmly bound): The full clause has been regarded by others, such as Bradley, *Anglo-Saxon Poetry*, as subordinate and *gebunden* as

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THE HUSBAND'S MESSAGE

- metaphorical ("now that I am firmly chastened," p. 389). Bliss and Frantzen, "Integrity," translate, "now that I am in firm control," but note that their interpretation is conjectural. See Klinck, *Old English Elegies*, 194.
 48–49 *Giet biþ þæt selast, þonne mon him sylf ne mæg wyrd onwenden, þæt he þonne wel þolige* (Still it is always best when one cannot avoid fate that he should then endure it well): See *Guthlac B*, lines 1348–51, and *Maxims I*, line 80, for parallel constructions for this gnomic wisdom.
 49 *wyrd* (fate): See note to *The Wanderer*, line 5.

PHARAOH

- 6 *siex hundra godra searo-hæbbendra* (six hundred chariots full of good warriors): See *Exodus* 14:7.
 7 *þæt eal fornam yþa færgripe* (the sudden grip of waves took all that): See *Exodus* 14:28.

THE HUSBAND'S MESSAGE

- 13 *beam* (tree): This could refer to a rune stick on which a message is written, as many scholars have assumed, or to the mast of the ship, as Niles, "Trick of the Runes," 203–4, has cogently argued.
 19 *freondscype* (friendship): See *The Wife's Lament*, line 25.
 23 *geomorne geac* (sad cuckoo): See *The Seafarer*, line 53, and note.
 32 *alwaldend God* (all-ruling God): Leslie, *Three Old English Elegies*, reads this as the only overtly Christian reference in the poem.
 49–50  *ic ætsomne⁴ᵣ geador ƿƿ7M aþe benemman* (I hear S R together EA W and M declare an oath): How the runes function in this passage is a matter of dispute. If they stand for letters of the alphabet, no one knows what they spell, although "sword" has been suggested (see Leslie, *Three Old English Elegies*, 15); if they stand for words, several scholars have offered interpretations. Leslie, for example, translates, "I hear heaven, earth and the man declare together by oath" (17), but that requires taking R and EA for something other than what *The Rune Poem* says they

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